

FREE LEAD MAGNET • THE SKILL MILL

The Container Garden Seed Calendar

Month-by-month seed-starting guide for USDA zones 3-10. Tomatoes. Herbs. Greens. Peppers. All of it.

Print it, circle your zone, and never miss another planting window.

Find your USDA zone first

Every planting date in this PDF references your USDA Hardiness Zone — specifically your average **last spring frost** date, which is the pivot point for almost every seed-starting decision. Look up your zip code at planthardiness.ars.usda.gov before doing anything else.

Zone	Last spring frost (avg)	First fall frost (avg)	Growing season	Notable regions
3	Late May - Early Jun	Mid September	90-110 days	Northern MN, ND, interior AK
4	Mid - Late May	Late September	110-130 days	MT, WI, VT, northern NY
5	Mid May	Early October	130-150 days	Chicago, Denver, Boston inland
6	Early - Mid May	Mid October	150-175 days	St. Louis, KC, central PA, NJ
7	Mid April	Late October - Early Nov	175-200 days	Richmond, Tulsa, OKC, Reno
8	Late March - Early April	Mid November	200-230 days	Atlanta, Dallas, Seattle
9	Late Feb - Early March	Late November - Early Dec	230-280 days	Houston, Orlando, Sacramento
10	Rarely frosts	Rarely frosts	Year-round	South FL, coastal CA, HI lowlands

The three dates that run your season

Last spring frost — pivot for transplanting warm-season crops (tomato, pepper, squash).

First fall frost — pivot for ending tender crops; fall-planting cool crops to beat.

Soil temperature — germination floor for most seeds. Use a \$8 soil thermometer. Seriously.

Legend for the calendar on the next page: [S] Start seeds indoors · [T] Transplant outdoors · [D] Direct sow outdoors · [H] Harvest window · [F] Frost risk — protect.

Month-By-Month Calendar (Zones 3-5, 6-7, 8-10)

Rows are the 15 most common container crops. Circle your zone column. Weekly check-ins beat heroics.

Zones 3-5 (cold)

Crop	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
Tomatoes				S	S	T	H	H	H			
Peppers (sweet/hot)			S	S		T		H	H			
Lettuce + greens				S	D	H	H		D	H		
Spinach			S/D	D	H	H		D	D	H		
Kale			S	T/D	H	H	H		D	H	H	
Arugula				D	D	H	H	D	D	H		
Herbs — basil				S	S	T	H	H	H			
Herbs — parsley/cilantro			S	D	D	H	H	H	D	H		
Cucumber					S/D	T	H	H				
Zucchini					D	T	H	H	H			
Peas				D	D	H	H					
Bush beans					D	D	H	H	H			
Radishes				D	H	H		D	H	H		
Carrots				D	D	H	H	D	H	H		
Strawberries				T	T	H	H	H				

Zones 6-7 (temperate)

Crop	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
Tomatoes			S	S	T	T	H	H	H	H		
Peppers (sweet/hot)		S	S	T	T	H	H	H	H			
Lettuce + greens		S	S/D	D	H	H	H	D	D	H		
Spinach			D	D	H	H		D	H	H		
Kale		S	S/D	T	H	H	H	D	T	H	H	H
Arugula		D	D	D	H	H		D	D	H		
Herbs — basil			S	S	T	H	H	H	H			
Herbs — parsley/cilantro		S	D	D	H	H	H	D	D	H	H	

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Cucumber				S	D	T	H	H	H			
Zucchini				S	D	T	H	H	H	H		
Peas			D	D	H	H		D	D	H		
Bush beans				D	D	H	H	H	H			
Radishes		D	D	D	H	H		D	D	H	H	
Carrots			D	D	H	H		D	D	H	H	
Strawberries			T	T	H	H	H	H				

Zones 8-10 (warm)

Crop	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
Tomatoes		S	T	T	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	
Peppers (sweet/hot)	S	S	T	T	H	H	H	H	H	H		
Lettuce + greens	D	D	H	H	H			D	D	H	H	D
Spinach	D	D	H	H				D	D	H	H	H
Kale	S	D	T	H	H	H		S	T	H	H	H
Arugula	D	D	H	H				D	D	H	H	H
Herbs — basil		S	T	T	H	H	H	H	H	H		
Herbs — parsley/cilantro	S	D	D	H	H	H		S	D	H	H	H
Cucumber			S	D	T	H	H	H	H	H		
Zucchini		S	D	D	T	H	H	H	H	H		
Peas	D	D	H	H				D	D	H	H	
Bush beans			D	D	H	H	H	H	H	H		
Radishes	D	D	H	H				D	D	H	H	H
Carrots	D	D	H	H	H			D	D	H	H	H
Strawberries	T	T	H	H	H	H	H			T	T	

Container Size Guide for 15 Common Vegetables

Container failure = root failure. These are **minimum** sizes. Bigger is always fine; smaller is why your tomato died in August. Width drives root spread; depth drives drought tolerance.

Crop	Min. size	Depth	Plants / container	Notes
Tomato (indeterminate)	10-15 gal	14-18"	1	Cage or trellis a must. Self-watering helps in heat.
Tomato (determinate/bush)	5-7 gal	12"	1	Great for patio-variety cultivars.
Pepper (sweet or hot)	3-5 gal	10-12"	1	Black pots warm soil faster in cool zones.
Lettuce	6"+ window box	6-8"	3-4 per foot	Cut-and-come-again every 10 days.
Spinach	6"+ window box	6-8"	3 per foot	Bolts over 75°F. Plan spring/fall only.
Kale	3 gal	10"	1	Tolerates frost down to 20°F. Fall crop all-star.
Arugula	6" window box	6"	3-4 per foot	Fastest salad green; 25 days seed-to-plate.
Basil	2 gal	8-10"	1	Pinch flowers weekly. Don't let it bolt.
Parsley / cilantro	2 gal	8-10"	2-3	Cilantro bolts fast in heat — succession plant.
Cucumber	5-7 gal	12"	1 (+trellis)	Vertical growing saves space massively.
Zucchini	10 gal	14"	1	Needs pollinators or hand-pollinate.
Peas	2-3 gal	10"	4-6 (+trellis)	Sugar snap on a trellis = vertical magic.
Bush beans	3 gal	10"	3-4	Cool-season quitters; start after last frost.
Radishes	6"+ window box	6-8"	10 per foot	21-30 days seed-to-harvest. Gateway crop for kids.
Carrots (short)	5 gal	12"	8-12	Pick short varieties: Thumbelina, Parisian, Nantes.
Strawberries	5 gal strawberry pot	10"	1 per pocket	Day-neutral varieties fruit all summer.

Quick Pest Troubleshooting

If you look at a plant and something is wrong, odds are very high it's one of these six. Start with the cheapest intervention that matches the symptom. Escalate only if the first pass fails.

Symptom	Likely culprit	First move
Holes in leaves, green droppings	Cabbage loopers / worms	Hand-pick at dusk. Bt (<i>Bacillus thuringiensis</i>) spray if widespread.
Sticky leaves, curling new growth	Aphids	Blast with water. Follow with insecticidal soap 2-3x, 3 days apart.
White powdery coating on leaves	Powdery mildew	Improve airflow. Milk + water spray (1:9) every 5 days. Remove w
Tiny black specks / webbing undersides	Spider mites	Spray undersides forcefully. Neem oil weekly. Thrive in dry heat.
Yellow lower leaves, slow growth	Nitrogen deficiency / overwatering	Check drainage first. Fish emulsion or balanced liquid fertilizer.
Flowers drop, no fruit	Poor pollination (common in containers)	Hand-pollinate tomatoes (tap the flower); attract bees with basil/m

The weekly Sunday check (2 minutes)

Water? Finger-test 2 inches down. If dry, water deeply until it drains.

Prune? Snip dead leaves, pinch basil flowers, sucker tomatoes below the first flower cluster.

Pest? Flip 3 leaves per plant, look underneath. Early detection = easy fix.

Fertilize? Liquid feed every 2 weeks during fruiting. Skip if soil is fresh compost-rich.

Your personal planner

The printable planner below is included as page 9 (next page). Fill it in once and you've got your season on one sheet.

Container Gardening Planner — on Etsy

Printable + fillable PDF. Seed-starting tracker, container inventory, weekly care log, and companion-plant chart. Works beside this calendar.

Grab it here:

Container Gardening for Small Spaces

Green Thumb Guides. The full book: 120+ container-crop database, companion-plant chart, balcony vs rooftop vs patio strategies, self-watering builds, and seasonal recovery plans.

My Container Garden — Planner Worksheet

Fill this in once at the start of the season. Keep it near your seed stash.

My USDA Zone:	
My last spring frost date:	
My first fall frost date:	
Balcony / patio / yard size:	
Hours of direct sun per day:	
Water source proximity:	

My container inventory

- [] 5-gallon bucket(s) — count: ____
- [] Window box(es) — count: ____
- [] 10-gallon grow bag(s) — count: ____
- [] Self-watering planter(s) — count: ____
- [] Hanging basket(s) — count: ____
- [] Raised bed / trough — sq ft: ____

My "plant these this year" shortlist (pick 5)

#	Crop	Variety	Container	Start date	Target harvest
1					
2					
3					

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4					
5					

Every Sunday, check: water? prune? pest? fertilize?

That one-line reminder is 80% of container-garden success. Tape it to your fridge.